



RURAL LIFE

Rural life became extremely tough after the collapse of large, state-run farms in the 1990s, and many people lived in poverty. Since then, private-owned, small-scale farms have become more common and productive. Grains—mainly wheat and barley—and sunflower oil are the top agricultural exports.



Icons, common in the Russian Orthodox Church, are religious images painted on wooden panels.



THE RUSSIAN CHURCH
The main religion in Russia is the Russian Orthodox Church. Under communism, all religion was banned, and churches and monasteries were left to decay. Today, many of these historic buildings have been restored, and many Russians attend church services regularly.



THE TATARS

Russia's largest ethnic minority, the Tatars (below), are an Islamic people descended from the Mongols. Their largest population lives in the Tatarstan Republic, midway between Moscow and the Urals.



The title tsar, or czar, once used for Russian rulers, means "emperor" and comes from the ancient Roman title "Caesar."

MOSCOW METRO

Not many underground railways can claim to be tourist attractions, but Moscow's metro can. Built in the 1930s, many of its stations are decorated with beautiful chandeliers, mosaics, paintings, and sculptures. One of the busiest, most efficient metros in the world, it is used by more than 7 million people daily.

Industrial smog casts a haze over Moscow.

POLLUTION

The communists invested heavily in industry, but their outdated methods of production are still affecting the environment. Rivers such as the Volga are badly polluted, and many cities are covered in a permanent and poisonous smog. Chest infections and other diseases related to air pollution are common.